# Twelve Everyday Things to Notice About Mom's Ordinary Week

What to notice and write down about how her week works, without reading anything into it.

You see Mom on Sundays. Most of her week happens on the other six days, and a lot of what keeps it running goes unremarked. This guide names twelve everyday things to notice about an ordinary week and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. Nothing on this list is a warning sign, and none of it measures how Mom is doing; it is a way of describing a week. If a routine is different from how it used to be, write what changed and roughly when, and stop there. The areas follow the lists of everyday activities and caregiving tasks in the federal long-term care glossary, MedlinePlus, AARP's planning guide and the Family Caregiver Alliance. The wording about what to write down is ours.

## Mornings

### 1 How the day starts

NOTICE When she's usually up, what the first hour looks like, and whether anyone phones or stops by early.

WRITE DOWN Her usual morning in two or three lines, in her words where you can.

### 2 Meals and the kitchen [1]

NOTICE Who buys the food, who cooks, and what a usual breakfast, lunch and supper are.

WRITE DOWN Who shops and who cooks, and on which days.

### 3 Medicines [1] [4]

NOTICE Whether there's a written list of what she takes, who picks up the refills, and whether anyone helps set them out.

WRITE DOWN Who does which part. A question about a medicine itself goes to her doctor or pharmacist, not onto the page.

## Daytime

### 4 Getting around [2] [3]

NOTICE Where she drives herself, and who gives her a ride when she doesn't. Your sister's Thursday drive to appointments belongs here.

WRITE DOWN Each regular trip, and who is behind the wheel.

### 5 Errands and shopping [2]

NOTICE The pharmacy, the post office, the grocery store: which she does herself, and which someone does with her or for her.

WRITE DOWN The regular errands, and who does each.

### 6 The house and the yard [1] [3]

**NOTICE** Laundry, cleaning, the lawn, the gutters, the smoke detector battery. Some of these come round weekly and some twice a year.

**WRITE DOWN** Each job and who does it, including the rare ones.

### 7 Mail, bills and paperwork [1]

**NOTICE** Who brings in the mail, who opens it, who pays the bills and who keeps the files.

**WRITE DOWN** Who handles each, and where the papers are kept.

## Evenings and overnight

### 8 Evenings and check-ins [3]

**NOTICE** What a usual evening looks like, and who phones or texts and when. The Wednesday night call counts.

**WRITE DOWN** A usual evening, and each regular call with the person who makes it.

### 9 Overnight

**NOTICE** Whether she's on her own at night, who lives nearest, and who has a key.

**WRITE DOWN** Who lives closest, who has a key, and who she'd phone first.

## The people around her

### 10 Appointments [4]

**NOTICE** Who makes them, who keeps the calendar, who goes along and who hears what was said.

**WRITE DOWN** Her regular appointments, and the person attached to each.

### 11 Company and outings [2] [3]

**NOTICE** Church, cards, the hairdresser, lunch with a friend, the grandchildren's games: where she goes and who she sees.

**WRITE DOWN** The regular ones, and who she goes with.

### 12 The jobs only one person knows

**NOTICE** The things one person handles that nobody else knows how to do: which pharmacy, where the spare key is, how the thermostat is set.

**WRITE DOWN** Each of those jobs, and the one person who knows it.

> **When a note isn't the right place**
>
> Nothing on this list calls for action; it describes an ordinary week. If you or Mom have a question about her health, take it to her doctor instead of working it out on the page. You don't have to decide first whether it matters. An emergency is a call to emergency services, as it always is.

**What this guide doesn't do**

It doesn't say what anything you notice means, and it doesn't measure how Mom is managing or suggest she needs more help or less. It helps you describe her week. What a description means for care is for the professionals who assess a person.

## Ready for the next step?

You've noticed how an ordinary week works and put it in writing. The care interview covers the same week more thoroughly: it asks about Mom's daily life area by area, flags what is still incomplete, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

**Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›**

### WHERE THIS COMES FROM


1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Glossary
2. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregivers
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver